

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 6-8

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 6

Men with Blankets

WE WERE NOT AFRAID of the *Nahullos* in the swamp. *Nahullos* didn't know the swamp. Snakes and alligators lived in the swamp, and it was hard to tell the ground from a mudhole. We Choctaws knew to be careful, with every step, but the *Nahullos* didn't know the swamp.

But winter changed everything. The swamp froze in the winter. Snakes slept underground and even the deepest mudholes turned to ice. The *Nahullos* could ride their horses over the frozen swamp.

One morning I woke up and the world was white.

Even before I opened my eyes I felt the white. Everything was quiet, and I peeped through the branches of our lean-to. Ice hung from the trees and mounds of snow covered the ground.

This was a warning. On this white day, many people would become ghosts. Many of the old men and women would become ghosts, and many children, too.

“Be very quiet,” my mother said. “*Nahullos* are coming.” I looked for my father, but he was gone. I held Jumper close.

I heard the horses first. They snorted and wheezed, and soon I heard the wagons. The wooden wagon wheels crunched and cracked the ice. I was afraid. Everyone was afraid. My father came into the lean-to.

“Stay here,” he said.

The wagons slowly crossed the swamp and came into our lean-to town. Everyone hid. We were so quiet. We looked through the branches.

The men on the wagons were *Nahullo* soldiers. They wore uniforms. They jumped to the ground and reached for something in the wagons.

“Guns,” Luke said. “They will shoot us.”

“Shhhh,” my mother whispered.

When the men turned around, they didn’t have guns. They had blankets and they smiled. We were all freezing from the cold and the *Nahullo* soldiers had blankets.

“The blankets are for you!” a soldier shouted.

At first no one moved.

“Come and get the blankets!” another soldier yelled.

Old Man was the first Choctaw to leave his lean-to. Old Woman followed after him. The soldier smiled and gave Old Man a blue blanket. Old Man wrapped himself in the blanket and turned around for everyone to see.

“Nice and warm. *Yakoke*,” said Old Man.

Old Woman took the second blanket and threw it over her shoulders.

“*Yakoke*,” she said. She buried her head in the blanket and shook with joy.

Many Choctaws ran for the blankets. Mothers and children took the blankets. Fathers took enough blankets for everyone in their lean-to.

“*Yakoke!*” they told the soldiers. “Thank you!”

When I tried to leave our lean-to, my mother grabbed my arm and pulled me back inside.

“Sit down,” she told me.

“I want a blanket,” I said.

My mother held my head on her shoulder. She ran her hand through my hair, and I felt warm next to her. “We do not need their blankets,” she whispered in my ear.

Luke tried to run for a blanket, but my mother pulled him back, too. She drew him inside the lean-to.

“Sit next to me,” she said.

Luke sat on one side of my mother and I sat on the other. My father stood over us and watched. No one left our lean-to that morning.

“We do not need their blankets.” My mother whispered this. Over and over she whispered, “We do not need their blankets.”

After the soldiers left, everyone was happy. For a few days, everyone was happy.

“We don’t have to be afraid anymore,” Old Man shouted.

“We can build our fires high!” said Old Woman.

Our neighbors left their lean-tos and visited and laughed. Jumper barked and played with the other dogs. But my father and mother were not happy, not like the others. We were still freezing cold.

“Luke and Isaac, stay in the lean-to,” my father said. “Do not go near anybody. Stay here.”

While everybody else slept that night, my father and Luke went hunting. They returned with two small squirrels, and we cooked them over the fire for breakfast.

Old Man saw the smoke from our cooking fire and stuck his head under our lean-to.

“Come outside,” he said. “I’ll share my blanket.”

I looked at his face. I felt the warm shiver from inside, like before. I closed my eyes, and when I opened them, Old Man was not smiling. His face was red and swollen and a red sore lay next to his nose. Then another sore appeared, on his lip. Soon his cheeks were covered in sores.

Old Man fell to the ground. He rolled out of his blanket and buried his face in the snow.

“I don’t want to see this!” I shouted. I covered my face with my hands.

“What is wrong with you?” Luke said. He pulled my hands apart. When I looked up, Old Man was staring at me. The sores were gone.

“Are you all right?” he asked.

“Yes,” I said. “I am sorry. I am cold, that’s all.” I didn’t want to lie, but I couldn’t tell him what I knew. I knew that Old Man and Old Woman would soon be ghosts.

I almost became a ghost that day. If my mother hadn’t pulled me back, I would have become a ghost.

How could my mother have known?

Years later, after I did become a ghost, I asked myself.

How did she know?



Chapter 7

Snow Monsters

HOKE. *EVERYTHING WAS sad, rotten sad. I was ten years old. This was no way to live! In many ways, when you are ten years old, you are smarter than grown-ups. But sometimes your parents are smart, too.*

The very next day, my father and mother were smart. After breakfast (more squirrel), they looked at each other for a long time. I knew they had something planned.

“Luke, Isaac, we are going for a walk, without your mother,” my father said. “Isaac, carry Jumper. Hold him tight and don’t let him go.”

We climbed out of the lean-to and walked away from the camp. We crossed the icy swamp, on the far side of the island.

“Careful,” my father warned. “Do not fall through the ice!”

Jumper wiggled, trying to get free.

“I want to run,” Jumper said. “Let me go!”

“Not yet,” I told him.

We walked for almost an hour.

“Now,” my father said, “let Jumper go. He’s ready to run.”

“You heard your father,” Jumper said. “Let me down!”

I dropped him and Jumper took off running.

“I am faster than you are,” Jumper called over his shoulder. I had to laugh.

Of course, he was faster than me! I ran after him anyway. I tripped over a log covered in snow and rolled and tumbled.

“Be careful!” my father shouted.

When I came to my feet, my face was covered in snow. Luke laughed and pointed at me.

“You are a snow monster!” he said.

I didn’t know what a snow monster was. I just knew I didn’t like being called one. I grabbed a handful of snow and rolled a snowball.

Hoke. You are smart enough to know what I did next. I threw the snowball at Luke. He ducked and the snowball hit my father — in the face!

This was bad, real bad. I had never hit my father with a snowball. I stood and waited.

“Uh-oh,” Luke said.

“Uh-oh,” Jumper said.

We waited to see what my father would do. First he stepped behind a tree. Luke and I looked at each other.

“This is strange,” Jumper said.

The tree was covered in icicles and we heard cracking sounds. My father was breaking icicles from the branches. We stood still for a long time. What happened next was scary, really scary.

“Grrrrr!” A low growling sound came from behind the tree.

“Grrrrrrrrr!” The sound grew louder.

“I don’t like this,” Jumper said.

Without warning, something jumped from behind the tree!

"I am the real snow monster!" the thing yelled.

The snow monster wore my father's clothes. He had no hands. Icicles poked from his sleeves, where his fingers should be. And his head was made of snow.

The snow monster ran after us. He waved his arms and icicles flew all around us. He tackled Luke. They both rolled in the snow.

"Grrrr!" the thing yelled.

"Where is your father?" Jumper asked.

"No time for talking," I said. "Run!"

"Help!" Luke shouted.

"You are on your own," said Jumper. "I do not fight snow monsters!"

I thought the snow monster *was* my father, but Jumper and I didn't wait to see. We hid behind a big rock and clung to each other. The snow monster dragged Luke behind the tree. We heard more cracking sounds.

"Grrrrr!" That was the snow monster growling.

"Grrrrrrrrr!" That sounded like Luke, growling *like* a snow monster.

I knew what was about to happen. Big Snow Monster jumped out: "Grrrrr!"

When Little Snow Monster appeared, I laughed. It was scary, but I laughed anyway.

"Grrrrrrr! I am Son of Snow Monster!" Little Snow Monster yelled.

Little Snow Monster was wearing Luke's clothes! His fingers were icicles and his head was a giant snowball.

"Hey, I want to be a snow monster!" I said.

Big Snow Monster looked at Little Snow Monster. I never knew snow monsters could shrug their shoulders. These two did.

“Come on,” said Big Snow Monster.

We all went behind the tree, but Jumper stayed behind the rock. He was still scared and didn't want to be close to any snow monster.

My father (*hoke*, he was not a real snow monster) broke icicles from the tree. Luke (Little Snow Monster) scooped up enough snow to make me a snow monster head. I knew what we were about to do.

“Jumper likes to run,” my father said. “We'll give him a good reason to run.”

Jumper jumped on top of the rock.

“What’s going on?” he asked.

We didn’t answer. Soon I was ready, with icicle fingers and a snowy head.

“Grrrrr!” we growled from behind the tree.

“Go,” my father whispered.

We jumped into the open.

“Grrrrrrr!”

Jumper did not move. He was so afraid he just stared at us. Then he leapt from the rock and started running.

We waved our arms and flung icicles. We shook our heads and snow flew everywhere.

“Help!” shouted Jumper.

We chased Jumper through the trees and up a hill. I knew Jumper was fast, but he ran faster than ever! That’s what happens when you’re a dog being chased by three snow monsters.

Finally, Jumper stopped. Our icicle fingers were gone. Our snow heads were gone.

“Hey!” said Jumper. “That is not funny. You are not snow monsters. You are Luke, Isaac, and Father.”

“I’m sorry, Jumper,” I said. “We played a joke, that’s all.”

“Let’s go home, now,” my father said. “Jumper, we will make you something special for supper tonight.”

“I think I deserve it,” said Jumper. He was already wagging his tail. I knew he forgave us.

I learned something important that day. Hitting your father in the face with a snowball is not a good idea — unless you want to spend the rest of the day with real live Choctaw snow monsters.

I learned something else, too. Being a snow monster was better than being a ghost.



Chapter 8

Walking People

LUKE AND MY FATHER went hunting that afternoon. They returned with a deer! We roasted our first deer since leaving home. My mother gave Jumper the first piece of deer meat.

The next morning Old Man and Old Woman stayed in their lean-to. Most of our Choctaw friends stayed inside, too, curled up in their blankets. No one laughed.

By afternoon Choctaw people from every lean-to moaned and cried. Old people, young people, everyone cried. As day turned to darkness, a young girl shouted, "I am burning." Her mother ran to the swamp and brought her a cup of water.

“We should get a good night’s sleep,” my father said. “We will be leaving in the morning.”

“Where will we go?” my mother asked.

“Away,” my father answered. “Far away.”

“I hate to leave our friends,” Mother said.

“So do I,” said my father. “But there is nothing we can do to help them.”

I had a bad dream that night. I dreamed of what would happen in a few days. Old Man and Old Woman were covered in sores. They itched and burned and the sores never went away. Everyone with a blanket had the sores.

How did my mother know? I asked myself. How did she know the blankets carried smallpox?

Smallpox was a dark secret. It climbed from the blankets and carried the sores. I had already seen smallpox, but I didn’t know it.

A week earlier, when I saw Old Man and Old Woman playing like children in the river, I saw smallpox. With my ghost eyes, I saw it.

Some Choctaws became ghosts from the shotguns. Some became ghosts from the burning houses. But the blankets made more ghosts than any guns or fires. The smallpox blankets were ghost-making blankets.

Our days in the swamp were over.

Early the next morning we gathered our belongings and left the camp. We walked all day and slept in the woods.

The next morning we came to a road. As far as we could see, Choctaw people were walking. Soldiers drove wagons and Choctaws walked. The roads were covered with snow and ice.

Most of the Choctaws had blankets wrapped around their shoulders. When my father saw the blankets he pulled us close. We followed this band of soldiers and walking Choctaws for three days, hiding in the tree shadows, unseen by anyone.

I carried Jumper so he couldn't chase the walking people. But he didn't even try to get away. After the *Nahullos* burned our town, Jumper knew when to be quiet. He seemed to understand about the ghosts, too, so I asked him.

"Do you see the ghosts, Jumper?"

"Do you promise not to tell?" he said.

"I won't tell anyone. I promise."

“Okay,” said Jumper. “I see the ghosts. Maybe I will be a ghost soon.”

“Jumper, no!”

Jumper just looked at me. I think he knew that I would soon be a ghost. We never spoke of it again.

On the morning of the fourth day, my father stepped out of the tree shadows and spoke to a friendly Choctaw man passing by.

“My family has no place to go,” my father said. “Our town was burned and we have been living in the woods.”

“You can come with us,” the man said. “My name is Gabe. We are going to a new home, a home they will never take from us.”

“The blankets?” my father asked. “Did the soldiers give you the blankets?” I knew what he was thinking. He was remembering the ghost-making blankets.

“Yes,” Gabe said. “They are thick and warm.”

My father nodded. “I am Zeke, and this is my wife, Ochi. These are my sons, Luke and Isaac.”

“This is my wife, Ruth,” said Gabe. “You are welcome to join us.”

Ruth lifted her hand from under her blanket and waved. I couldn’t see her face, but I could hear her laughing under her blanket.

“I am coooold!” she said.

Ruth was short and round, and I knew she would be a funny friend. I saw something wiggling under her blanket.

“Momma!” a tiny voice said.

Ruth lifted her blanket and a little girl stood next to her.

"This is Nita," Ruth said.

Nita buried her face in the blanket.

"She is shy," said Ruth. "She is five years old."

"*Halito*, Nita!" we all said. She didn't look at us, but she waved.

"Just like her mother," Gabe said, and everybody laughed.

My family joined the walkers that day. After the burning of our town, the days in the swamp, and the blankets with small pox, my family joined the walkers. We were on our way to a new home.

But we were not alone.

Mister Jonah came to me the first night.

After sundown, Gabe and my father built a campfire close to the road. We had dried corn for our first night's meal. I was so hungry that I would have eaten the corn uncooked. But with wild onions, roasted over a log fire, it was delicious!

After supper we sat close to the fire.

"Do you want me to get you blankets?" Gabe asked my father. "The soldiers have blankets in the wagon."

"Not yet," my father said. "We will wait a few days."

We all slept close together. It was warmer that way. Sometime after midnight, when everyone else was asleep, I felt the warm shiver and sat up. The ghost of Mister Jonah sat next to me.

"We are waiting for you," he said.

"Did you die in the fire?"

“Yes, I did,” he said. “But I am not alone. Missus Jonah is with me. Are you ready to come with us?”

“No,” I told him. “I want to be with my family.”

“You will be with us soon,” he said, and stood to go.

“Wait,” I said. “I want to ask you something.”

“What?”

“Are the blankets safe?”

Mister Jonah smiled.

“Your mother was smart not to let you take a blanket in the swamp.”

“But these new blankets,” I asked, “are the new blankets safe?”

“Yes. The new blankets are safe.”

“Thank you,” I said. “I am glad you came.”

After he was gone, I woke my father up.

“The blankets are safe,” I whispered.

“How do you know?”

“I saw Mister Jonah. His ghost told me the new blankets are safe.”

“I will ask for blankets in the morning,” my father said.